partnership of 280 was instrumental in winning us the Test. It had taken the wind out of the West Indies' sails. Mohammed Shami, another debutant, finished the job in the second innings with an excellent spell of reverse-swing bowling, taking five wickets to add to his four in the first innings. He was getting the ball to move appreciably and has a bright career ahead.

We won the match by an innings and 51 runs in under three days. The awards ceremony turned into a special occasion, with tricolour balloons released to commemorate my 199th Test match, and I left Eden Gardens with some really pleasing memories.

Time to gather my thoughts

I decided to go back to Mumbai on the evening of 8 November to give myself more time at home before my 200th Test match. At Kolkata airport on the way back, a huge crowd started to walk with me everywhere I went. Luckily for me, there were eight armed commandos with me at the airport, as otherwise things might have got a little out of hand. It was slightly disconcerting because there was no way I could oblige the entire crowd with pictures and autographs and I asked the airport manager to take me to the lounge as quickly as possible. We walked to the far end of the terminal past the security check and it was only then that I saw it was a public lounge.

The crowd was continuing to follow me around and I asked the manager if we could go and sit in another lounge instead. He said this was the only available option after the security checkpoint and he would cordon off the area where I would be sitting. I wasn't prepared to do this because I didn't want to give people the wrong message. It was not as if I wasn't willing to meet them or sign autographs. I have never refused to sign autographs, because I consider it my duty towards my fans, who have stood by me throughout my careeer. However, if I did start to sign or pose for pictures, there was a risk that it would become a serious security issue inside the lounge.

It was then that I advised the duty manager to check if the aircraft was ready, hoping that I could go and sit in it. I was informed it was being cleaned but I thought it was still better to board it than to keep the crowd at a distance. I went in and sat all by myself. Once inside, I posed for pictures with all the cleaners and the crew that had brought the aircraft to